

SHOGI · VARIANT 17 OF 24

Minishogi

5×5
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

MINISHOGI

Minishogi was invented (or rediscovered) around 1970 by Shigenobu Kusumoto of Osaka, Japan. It applies Standard Shogi rules to a 5×5 board, reducing each player’s force to five pieces and the promotion zone to the single back rank. Game mechanics are not copyrightable; the rules have been freely published for over 50 years.



Minishogi — starting position

SETUP

Board: 5×5 grid, 25 squares.

Pieces per player: 6 (King, Rook, Bishop, Gold General, Silver General, one Pawn). No Knights or Lances: the board is too small for their jump.

Starting position:

PLAYER	RANK	PIECES (FILES 5–1, LEFT TO RIGHT)
White (top)	Rank 5	Rook · Bishop · Silver · Gold · King
White	Rank 4	Pawn at file 1 only
Black (bottom)	Rank 1	King · Gold · Silver · Bishop · Rook
Black	Rank 2	Pawn at file 5 only

PIECES

PIECE	MOVEMENT
King	One square in any direction. Cannot move into check.
Rook	Any number of squares orthogonally.
Bishop	Any number of squares diagonally.
Gold General	One step orthogonally or diagonally forward. Six directions.
Silver General	One step diagonally, or one step forward. Five directions.
Pawn	One step directly forward.

PROMOTION

The promotion zone is the final rank only (rank 5 for Black, rank 1 for White). A piece may promote when it moves into or within the promotion zone. Promotion is mandatory when the Pawn reaches the final rank with no other legal move.

Promoted pieces:

BASE PIECE	MOVEMENT WHEN PROMOTED
Rook	Dragon King: Rook moves plus one square diagonally
Bishop	Dragon Horse: Bishop moves plus one square orthogonally
Silver General	Moves as Gold General
Pawn	Tokin: moves as Gold General

Kings and Gold Generals do not promote.

DROPS

The drop mechanic applies as in Standard Shogi. Captured pieces are held in hand and may be dropped onto any empty square on a later turn, unpromoted. Restrictions: no Pawn drop on a file already containing a friendly unpromoted Pawn; no Pawn drop for immediate checkmate; no drop where the piece would have no legal move.

WIN CONDITION

Checkmate the opponent's King. A player with no legal moves loses.

DRAWS

Sennichite: The same position (including pieces in hand) occurs four times with the same player to move. Draw. If caused by perpetual check, the checking side loses.

Impasse: Both Kings enter the promotion zone and neither can be mated. Count material: Rooks and Bishops score 5 points each; all others score 1 point each. A player with fewer than 24 points loses. If both reach 24 or more, the game is a draw.

ATTRIBUTION

Minishogi. Invented (or rediscovered) c. 1970 by Shigenobu Kusumoto of Osaka. Rules freely published since then; game mechanics are not copyrightable. Sources: pychess.org/variants/minishogi; Fairy-Stockfish variants.ini engine definition.